

Finding Hope in Laying Slain Bodies in Jesus Wounded Hands

7 Easter C

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Gospel: John 17:20-26

Jesus prays that the life of his followers will be characterized by an intimate unity of identity with God. To be so identified with God means also to share in God's mission: to proclaim the word that will bring others into this same unity.

[Jesus prayed:] ²⁰"I ask not only on behalf of these, but also on behalf of those who will believe in me through their word, ²¹that they may all be one. As you, Father, are in me and I am in you, may they also be in us, so that the world may believe that you have sent me. ²²The glory that you have given me I have given them, so that they may be one, as we are one, ²³I in them and you in me, that they may become completely one, so that the world may know that you have sent me and have loved them even as you have loved me. ²⁴Father, I desire that those also, whom you have given me, may be with me where I am, to see my glory, which you have given me because you loved me before the foundation of the world.

²⁵"Righteous Father, the world does not know you, but I know you; and these know that you have sent me. ²⁶I made your name known to them, and I will make it known, so that the love with which you have loved me may be in them, and I in them."

Overview - Praying for You

Today's gospel reading is first and foremost a prayer. It is Jesus' prayer, and we are given the privilege of listening in as he prays on behalf of his disciples and people of all times and places. Listeners are given a glimpse of Jesus' mission for the world—that all may be drawn into the life of the triune God. On the eve of his death, Jesus entrusts this particular community of disciples—but also our communities, our lives, and our world—into the care of God. What is it Jesus is doing when he prays? What is it the church does when it prays on behalf of the world and other people? To be prayed for by another is to know one's life is cared for and has value to the one praying on your behalf. It is to know that much of the future is out of one's own control but rests instead in the care of the Triune God. To be prayed for is to be vulnerable, dependent, and deeply loved.

Here is the astoundingly good news: Jesus prays for you, and for the communities in which we find ourselves. Whether your cup is empty or full, whether your community is in crisis or experiencing joy, whether your future is foggy or clear, Jesus loves you deeply and your life is bound to the God who loved you before the foundations of the

world. On the eve of his death, Jesus entrusted your life and the church's life and its entire future to the Father. What glorious good news that the future rests in the care of the Triune God, and that we, the church, are set free to make God known to the world.

John 17:20-26

Our reading is from Jesus' *high priestly* prayer: he consecrates his body and blood for the sacrifice in which they will be offered, and he blesses the Church. Jesus' time of perfect obedience even to death has come, securing eternal life for all who really know him and, through him, the Father (vv. [1-5](#)). May the Father restore him to the place he enjoyed before creation began (v. [5](#)). In vv. [6-19](#), Jesus prays for his followers, that they may be protected from the evil, be "one" (v. [11](#)) as he and his Father are one, have "joy" (v. [13](#)), and fulfill his mission as his agents in the world. He now prays for the Church of all times. He looks beyond those who follow him now, to those who will come to believe through their witness. May the Church be rooted in the oneness he shares with the Father (v. [21](#)), a relationship of mutual love (v. [23](#)). May his followers attain the ultimate goal: to be with him in heaven (at the end of time), sharing in his "glory" (v. [24](#), in part by continuing his earthly ministry), given to him before time began. Christians know that the Father sent him (v. [25](#)); he has given them intimate knowledge of God ("... name", v. [26](#)) and will continue to do so, so that they may have the love for each other and for God that he and the Father share.

In the final discourse in the gospel of John, Jesus speaks a chapter-long prayer for his followers. In the concluding section, Jesus prays for unity among his followers: indeed, already at the close of the 1st century the Johannine community was dealing with divisions that existed among Christians. The excerpt includes all the major Johannine categories: Father, name, word, belief, glory, love, world. "World" is *kosmos*, both the place and the time in which God's will is enacted. The unity sought for believers is modeled on Johannine Christology: the Son is one with the Father. What has been called the High Priestly Prayer of John 17 is divided between the 3 years of the lectionary on the Sunday after the Ascension. Proclaiming John 17 after Easter rather than during Holy Week exemplifies not only the technique of the lectionary, which layers up biblical meanings for the church's worship life, but also the facts of the composition of the gospels: not a verbatim from Jesus' life, this chapter was crafted decades after the resurrection to hold before the believers the name of Christ and so to strengthen the community, who like Christ are both in the world and not in the world. The unity of the Son with the Father is to inspire and enable the unity of all Christ's followers.

In these concluding verses of the prayer that makes up John 17, Jesus says that the purpose of all he has asked for in the preceding verses is this: that all disciples of all time may be one in the specific sense in which Jesus and the Father are one, the mutual indwelling of love that has defined that relationship not only in the life of Jesus but also in the oneness of God and the creative Word from before the foundation of the world. Jesus prays for his own, the ones present and those who will believe in him through them (which means we can read it as a prayer for us), to be drawn into the love of the Father and Son-Word-Jesus.

Already Jesus has promised dwelling places in the house of God (14:2) and has promised that he and God will make dwelling places in us (14:23). Now Jesus speaks of and requests this oneness and refers to the mutual indwelling of himself and God, and of us with him and with God, 10 times in five verses. The word translated “completely” here in the NRSV is a verb form meaning that we are to be made perfect in oneness.

The purpose, he says, of this perfection of oneness is not only an experience of divine love for us in our communion with God and one another. The purpose is beyond us. This being perfected in oneness is so that the uncomprehending, sometimes dangerous world (1:10; 16:33; 17:25) may also believe and know God’s love in the sending of the Son (17:21 and 23; 3:16).

The oneness of the Father and Jesus is synonymous with love in John, and what the world is to see in our display of that oneness is the love of God miraculously made manifest. Our love for God and one another becomes then an offering in and for the world to experience the love through which all creation has come into being.

Like the love for one another in 13:34-35, which is a way for other people to see that we belong to Jesus, and like our oneness as branches nurtured by the vine and tended by the gardener God for our own fullness of joy and love, but also to bear fruit (15:1-11), the oneness Jesus asks for here among those who believe in him is not an exclusive club, but an invitation to the world—an invitation as open, loving, joyful, and fruitful as we can allow ourselves to be.

The Greek word translated “believe” also means “trust.” Believing in Jesus and in God (for example, 17:20; 1:12; 14:1) is presented in John not as an intellectual exercise but as being in a trusting relationship of love with someone who embodies God’s love for the world and who calls us friend. It is trusting him that love is the lodestar of life.

To understand what this looks like, we may look at how Jesus manifests God’s love for the world in himself—in what he does, what he says, and how he is—and also listen to what he says it means for us to love him, and by extension, one another and the world.

As Jesus tends, feeds, bears witness to, and breaks barriers for love, Jesus' own are called to do the same thing (15:27; 21:15-17).

The Gospel also explains how love is possible. This love clearly cannot depend on feelings of attraction, desire, affection or even liking. It is a behavior-shaping attitude toward the world, which is both a gift we cannot manufacture and a choice to live into the promises of that gift that is already given. We cannot paste it onto ourselves. Like branches of a vine, we live in something larger than ourselves, in which we are nurtured to bear fruit by the Spirit dwelling in us (about which we read in the Pentecost passage for next week). But because we are more than vines, we also become more loving by choosing to follow Jesus' model and teachings (13:14-15) about what love is: tending, feeding, bearing witness, and breaking barriers for love—societal barriers and also barriers we set up for ourselves, including some that we may think make us rightly religious but which do not make us loving.

This love is the substance of Jesus' glory. And it is what he wants us and the world to know.

Oneness and love are linked throughout the passage with knowledge, and that is where it concludes. To know God is to have love in us and to have Jesus in us. This also takes us back to where the prayer began, glory and knowledge. To know God in 17:2-3 is eternal life, and now we find that eternal life will be an extension of the love of God stretching back before the foundation of the world, forward to us, and beyond us to the communion of the saints and to those who may be able to experience God's love through us.

And so the Easter season culminates where the Gospel began: with Jesus making God known so that the world may know that every soul and all creation has come from and has a place in the creative love of God.

Images in the Readings

In polytheism, even the divine is multiple. But in monotheism, God and divine truth are understood as one. Thus Christian theology develops the theme of **unity**: the Trinity is one, and believers are one in a unity created by and shared with the one God. Christians have struggled with this image, since even in the first century the church was not visibly a single unified organization. In spite of our words in the Nicene Creed, "We believe in one holy catholic and apostolic church," separate denominations flourish, and sociologists suggest that this very diversity has led to more active membership. We can at least pray that God, looking at the church, sees us as one in Christ, and we can look at one another across denominational lines with gratitude for

the various ways that the Spirit leads us to live within that oneness. We join Paul and Silas, for we are all, at some time, in some way, in **prison**.

Comments from the Cloud of Witnesses

An essential aspect of relationships is thinking, hoping, dreaming, wishing, praying for and about the future. The portion of the prayer from John 17 that we hear today turns its attention to the future. In the complex and beautiful language of the prayer, we hear that the future of the disciples is possible because they are connected through Jesus to the Father. Jesus' desire is for the continuation of the relationship. We must recognize that we too are connected to God, that we are among those who come to believe. We are bound in that relationship of faith into oneness with the Father. We are sent forth because of that love, as the disciples were sent. It is our yearning to be united and connected to God that gathers us together here around this table to celebrate the eucharist. Even though Jesus vanished from the sight of the disciples, the love of the risen Lord did not disappear. It is among us and with us each time we come together to eat the bread and to share the cup. [Leslie G. Reimer, in *Homilies for the Christian People*, pp. 470-72.]

Prayer: *Lord Jesus Christ, your own mother looked on when your life ended in violence. Our hearts are pierced with grief and anger at the death of children and their teachers in the mass shooting in Uvalde. We commend the slain to your wounded hands, and their loved ones to your merciful heart, trusting only in the promise that your love is stronger than death, and that even now, you live and reign forever and ever. Amen.*